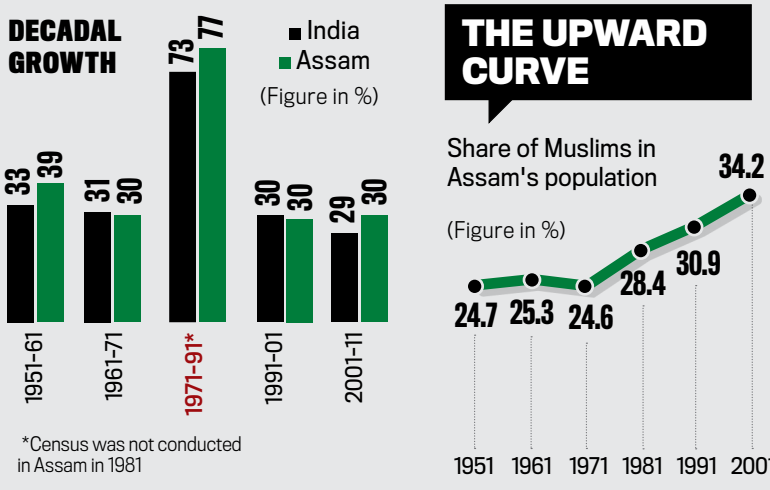
THE DEMOGRAPHIC DUEL

Assam's communal divide has its roots in the perception that the high growth among Muslims owes to "illegal immigration" from Bangladesh. The differential growth rate for Muslims in Assam compared to the national Muslim average feeds that notion. Some cite socio-economic factors, but the BJP has been cashing in on the native's fear of a demographic invasion.



Graphic by ASIT ROY

13-year-old niece was kidnapped by Muslims of immigrant origin in 2003 and rescued only after 23 days, was forced to relocate his monastery as the administration "failed to provide protection, thanks to vote bank politics". The BJP has come to power riding on the insecurities of many like Adhikary. Accepting Miyas as part of Assamese society will dilute its poll plank of providing security from "external aggressors". And yet, the 26-member committee that had proposed a *char-chapori* museum in Kalakshetra included six BJP MLAs. One of them was Padma Hazarika, who now says, "I don't remember what had been suggested in that report."

THE FEAR OF BANGLA

But discomfort with the assertion of Miya identity, especially a separate linguistic one, is not confined to those who support AASU or the BJP. In a heated debate in 2019, a series of public intellectuals took umbrage to a section of Muslims of immigrant origin writing poetry in their native Bangla dialect and calling it Miya poetry. This was seen as a challenge to the Assamese language, which has long been an emotive issue in the state. Bangla was imposed as a state language in Assam between 1836 and 1872. In the Barak Valley, which is dominated by Bangla-speakers, Assamese is still not accepted as the state language. The Assamese-speaking population in the state declined from 58 per cent in 1991 to 48 per cent in 2011, while the Bangla-speaking population grew from 22 to 29 per cent in the same period. Miya poetry, coming from a community whose members mostly go to Assamese-medium schools and often declare Assamese as their mother tongue, ended up provoking the fear that Assamese may lose the status of the language of the majority.

Take Dhubri district, for instance. Its population is nearly 80 per cent Muslim, largely of immigrant origin, but 69 per cent speak Assamese as per the 2011 census. That's because the majority of immigrant Muslims cite Assamese as their language. Hiren Gohain, an eminent intellectual and harsh critic of the BJP, questioned the idea of Miya poetry and argued that the community's decision to not use Assamese—a language adopted by their ancestors and declared as their mother tongue in the census—could shatter the fragile peace in Assam.

The police adds its bit, calling the museum part of a strategy instigated by "external factors", to carry forward the "job left half-done" by the now-banned Popular Front of India. "It's an exact replica of the RSS model of social penetration. The museum was a kind of experiment to test the waters," says a senior Assam police official.

Such "test cases", however, do not have the universal approval of the Miya community. Many among them believe a confrontational approach will do more harm than good. "Seeking acceptance as a part of Assamese culture should happen via dialogue and social empowerment," says Guwahati-based lawyer Aman Wadud, who had bailed out 10 poets arrested in 2019 on charges of spreading tension. "Did the person who set up the museum consult the community? Who authorised him to represent us or decide the nomenclature?" he asks. "I fought that battle as I was convinced they were not writing anything communal or xenophobic."

Wadud disfavours the aggressive tone of many social media posts by community youth. Nor is he alone in wanting the term Miya to be neither imposed nor brandished: he bats for freedom of choice. Comfortable in his skin as a Bengali Muslim who is now Assamese, he wishes everyone from the ethnicity to have the right to articulate identity in pursuit of dignity. "I can't say I have been accepted as Assamese even though I'm the fourth generation of our family living here," says Wadud. With politics permeating identity narratives, reconciliation doesn't appear imminent. After decades of seeking a secure border, the people of Assam have only found newer battlelines emerging in their midst. ■